

Digital Tools | Tips & Tricks

three pixels per leaf. This means the picture will lose out on details. For best results, shoot subjects that are clearly defined with smooth and distinct outlines, i.e., subjects that stand out well from the background. Unfortunately, most natural objects do not have this characteristic. When outdoors, the subjects to shoot are cars, buildings, cityscapes, and the like.

Black And White

 Colour contrast draws emphasis to subjects: Take a red apple against a green background, for instance. Use black and white when this emphasis is not important. However, in the apple example, if you shoot in colour and then convert to black and white in Photoshop, you find that green and red turn out almost identical. So, such photographs need to be shot in greyscale mode itself.  Remember that when you take a black and white picture, aspects such as shape, lighting, texture, etc, become dominant. Do you want it to be so? Also, do you want to give an old-world, somewhat sentimental feel to the picture?  Also, note that lighting plays more of a role in black and white pictures than in colour pictures. For example, when capturing a sunset, the shadows that the sun throws on objects are of more interest than the Sun itself.  Photographers use the term 'high-key' and 'low-key' for predominantly light and dark tones respectively. These determine the contrast level of the photograph. Now, note that high contrast steers



Here is an example of how colour can bring out the vibrance in a subject ...

the observer to look at particular subjects in the picture, and low contrast makes the observer look at the complete picture—its mood, subtle nature, etc.  Use filters to enhance your black and white pictures. A filter absorbs its complementary, or opposite, colour: for example, blue is the opposite of orange. Purchase an adapter ring for a filter. Perhaps your camera may already be equipped with a lens thread, in which case you will not need an adapter. Different colour filters have different effects.  Red filters tend to have a dramatic effect, and make a photo jump to life. Remember that red filters are not recommended for low-light conditions, or when you have an active subject—that is, one central object that is the whole idea of the photograph.  Yellow filters are the most popular for black-and-white photography. For example, they darken the blue sky, so white clouds come through with greater brilliance.



... while black and white loses out on it altogether, and introduces a different mood

 Orange filters darken blue even more, so you can create dramatic, magical effects. Try an orange filter for landscapes.  Green filters make greens lighter and reds darker. In landscapes or close-ups, leaves look brighter and red flowers darker.  Sky light or ultraviolet filters make for excellent lens protectors, and also act as a transparent-layer filter that absorbs ultraviolet light.

Close-ups And Macros (Extreme Close-ups)

 One of the problems with macro-photography is lighting. If you are too close to the subject, you may block out light yourself. Most inbuilt flashes are not good enough to light up macros. One solution is to use an external flash with a remote control. Another, easier one is to use an ordinary table lamp. A good idea with the table lamp is to cover it with something like tissue paper, which diffuses light.  Use supplementary lenses

Tip Of The Month

How important are steady hands while taking a picture?

Yes, the need for that cannot be overemphasised. Camera jitters are probably the prime cause of bad photographs. The problem is acute at slow shutter speeds, which are used in poor light. In other words, keep your hands as steady as possible when taking pictures in the evening, for example, or indoors without using a flash. Also, do remember that camera jitters worsen as you zoom in on the subject. A faster shutter speed is the simplest solution. Photographers often use the 'one-over-the-focal-length' rule to decide on a good shutter speed. For general digital cameras, here is a reckoner:

Wide-angle shot – 1/30
Medium-angle shot – 1/60
Zoom shot – 1/125
High-zoom shot – 1/250

If you have unsteady hands (and find it impossible to improve despite practice!), double these shutter speeds. For example, 1/30 becomes 1/60, and so on.

to magnify objects. These fit onto your camera's lens just like colour filters—you might need an adapter. They come in different strengths, measured in dioptres, such as +1, +2, etc. You can use more than one macro lens at the same time—with the higher-power lens placed closer to the main lens. However, this can result in loss of quality.



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